

worth ten times that amount, reselling them for an estimated eighty thousand dollars in profits. When she was caught, the trunk of her car was loaded with cardboard boxes stuffed with neatly stacked identical free coupons.

In January of 1990, Arvidson was sentenced to federal prison by a Dallas jury. When news stories about her went nationwide, a vague sense of unease reverberated through the coupon clipping community as a whole. For some, the hobby of coupon clipping was abandoned entirely. “*A housewife going to jail for using too many coupons?*” we wondered. “*Could I be next? Am I doing something wrong?*” For the first time in my history of couponing, I wasn’t proud to divulge the fact that I was an avid coupon user. I’d cringe at the checkout when I’d hand over my stack of coupons to the cashier, occasionally hearing, “These aren’t fake coupons are they, like that woman in Florida?” Extreme couponers throughout the nation experienced a collective shame.

A few years went by and everyone seemed to forget about “Coupon Connie.” I breathed a huge sigh of relief, reveling once again in my shopping skills and a local celebrity status as Coupon Queen.

At least I did until 2012, when the popular TLC series, *Extreme Couponing* brought an increased scrutiny of coupons at the checkout, and for good reason. Long-time couponers were up in arms after it was obvious that one of the first participants on the program had used coupons in a way that screamed “coupon misredemption,” taking advantage of the family coding of various coupons to use them on products they were not intended for. As if that weren’t suspicious enough, future episodes of *Extreme*